

surveydown

An Open-Source, Markdown-Based Platform
for Reproducible and Programmable Surveys

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About Me



- **Pingfan Hu**, PhD Candidate at George Washington University, advised by Dr. John Helveston.
- Research interests:
 1. **Data Science** in sustainable transportation and human behavior
 2. **Open-Source Software** in **R** tools for survey research
 3. **Agentic AI Engineering** around Claude Code
- For more information, visit pingfan.org

I try to figure out what people want...





Prof. John
Helveston



jhelvy.shinyapps.io

🦧

Welcome to the Ultimate Superhero Survey!

🦧

Thank you for participating in our research on superhero preferences and powers! This survey will help us understand what makes superheroes appealing to different people.

This survey should take about 3-5 minutes to complete.

Do you have a favorite super hero?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Next

WYSIWYG Interface

The screenshot shows the Google Forms editor interface. At the top, the browser address bar displays 'docs.google.com'. The form title is 'Super Hero Survey!'. Below the title, there are tabs for 'Questions', 'Responses', and 'Settings'. The 'Questions' tab is active. The main editing area shows a question: 'Do you have a favorite super hero?'. Below the question, there are three radio button options: 'Yes', 'No', and 'Add option or add "Other"'. A vertical toolbar on the right side of the editing area contains icons for adding different question types. A dropdown menu is open, showing the following options: 'Short answer', 'Paragraph', 'Multiple choice' (selected), 'Checkboxes', 'Dropdown', 'File upload', 'Linear scale', 'Rating' (marked as 'New'), 'Multiple choice grid', 'Checkbox grid', 'Date', and 'Time'. The 'Publish' button is visible in the top right corner.

Super Hero Survey!

Form description

Do you have a favorite super hero?

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Add option or [add "Other"](#)

Short answer

Paragraph

☒ Multiple choice

☒ Checkboxes

☒ Dropdown

☒ File upload

☒ Linear scale

☒ Rating **New**

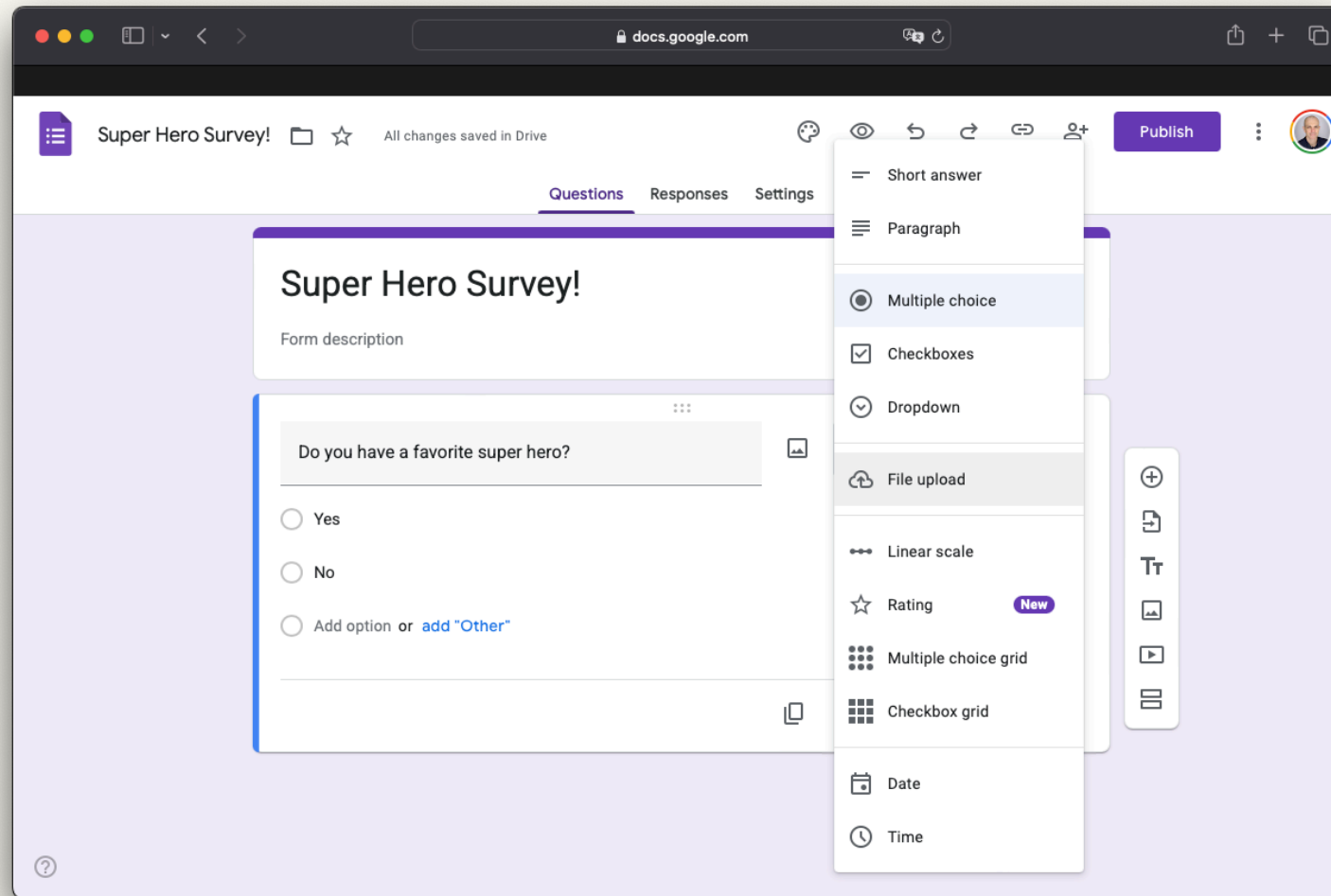
☒ Multiple choice grid

☒ Checkbox grid

☒ Date

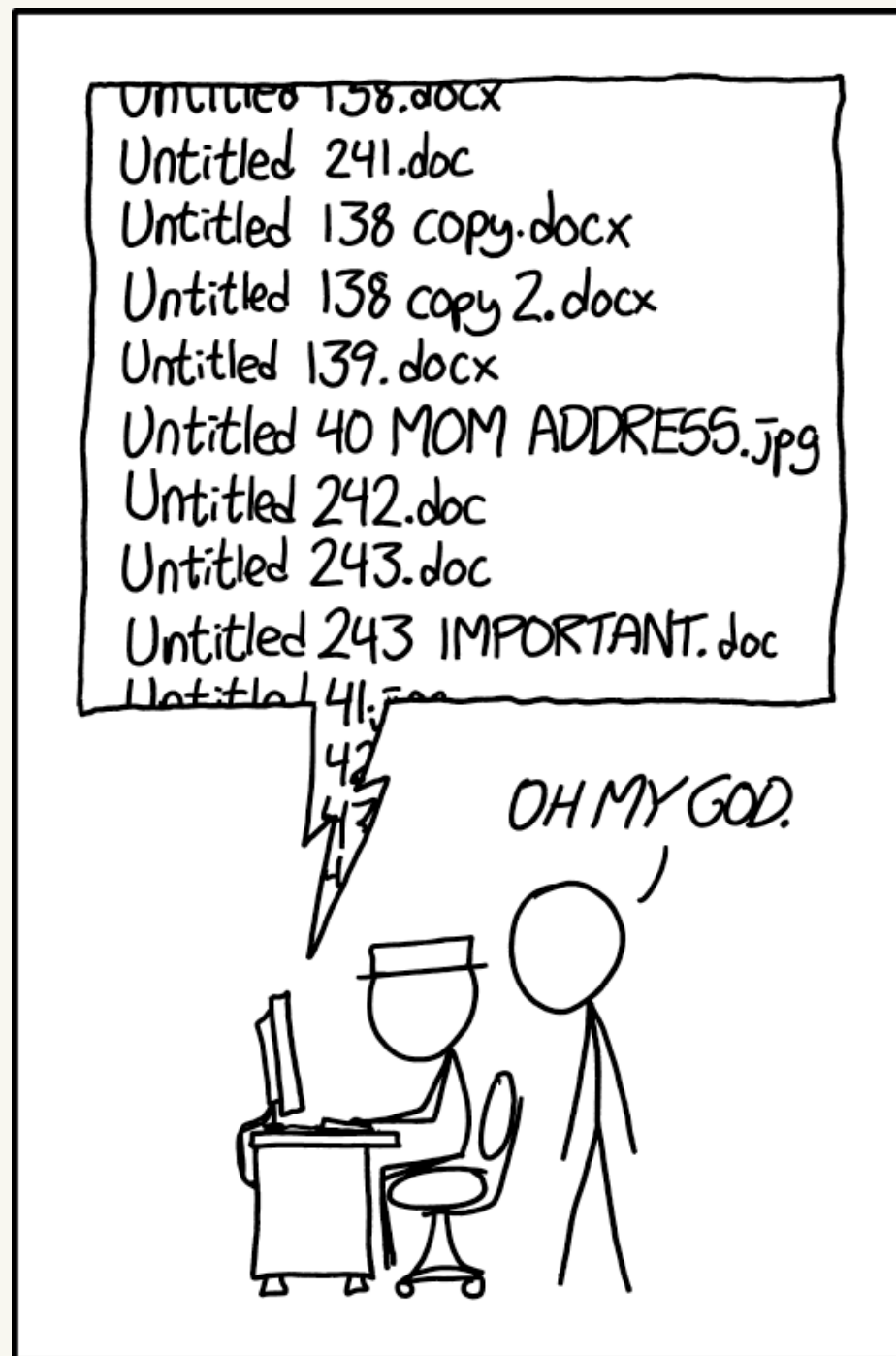
☒ Time

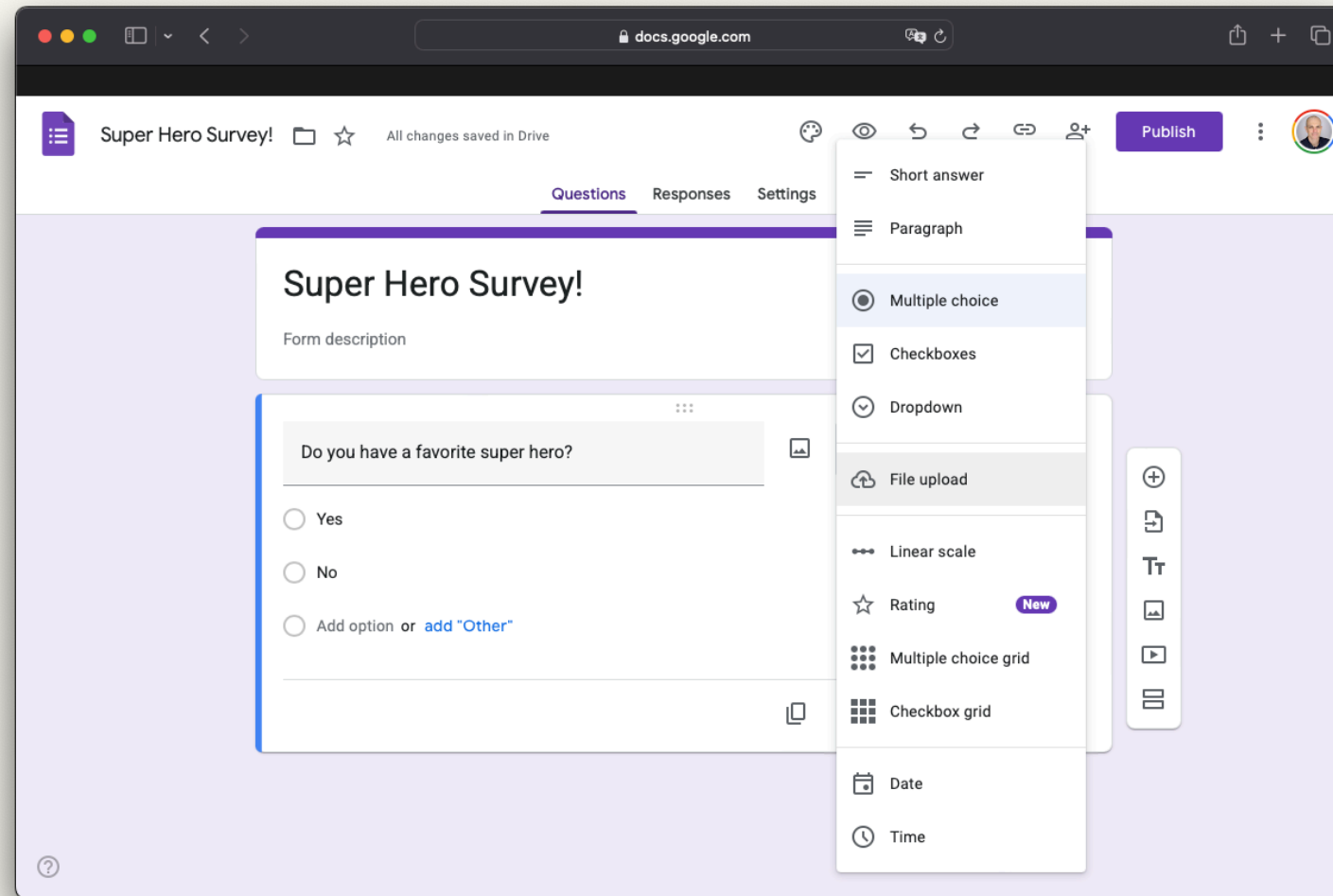
Publish



Limitations

- ✗ Reproducibility
- ✗ Version control





Limitations

- ✗ Reproducibility
- ✗ Version control
- ✗ Limited features
- ✗ Open source

Why not make surveys
from **code**?

~~Limitations~~

Features

- ✓ Reproducibility
- ✓ Version control
- ✓ Lots of features
- ✓ Open source

Introducing **surveydown**!



In this talk, we will cover:

What is surveydown?

How does it work?

What can I do with it?

What's next?

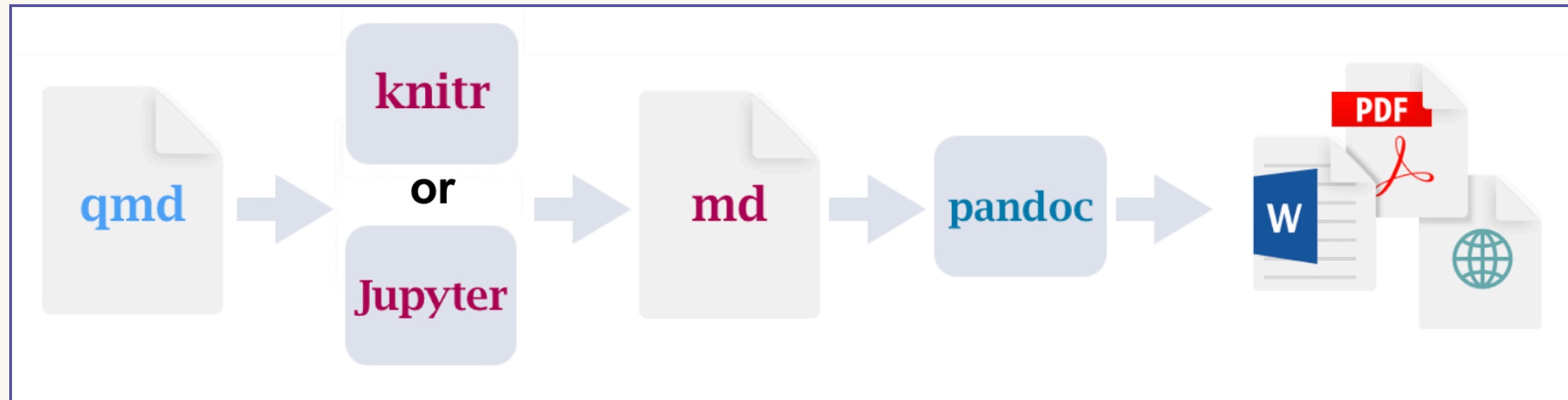
What is **surveydown**?



R package that renders Quarto files into surveys



Quarto is a publishing system

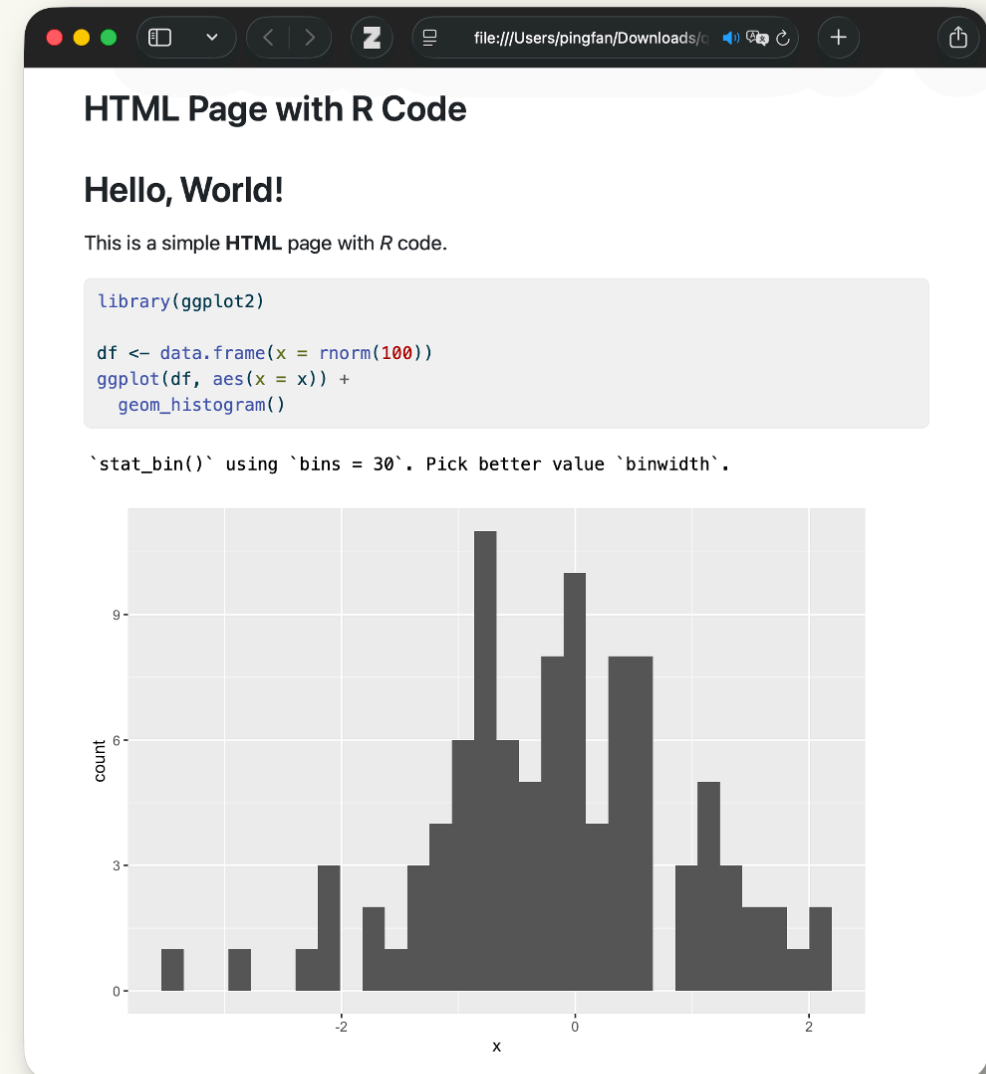


Original qmd file

Markdown + R code chunks

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 title: "HTML Page with R Code"
4 ---
5
6 # Hello, World!
7
8 This is a simple HTML page with R code.
9
10 ```{r}
11 library(ggplot2)
12
13 df <- data.frame(x = rnorm(100))
14 ggplot(df, aes(x = x)) +
15   geom_histogram()
16 ```
```

Rendered HTML

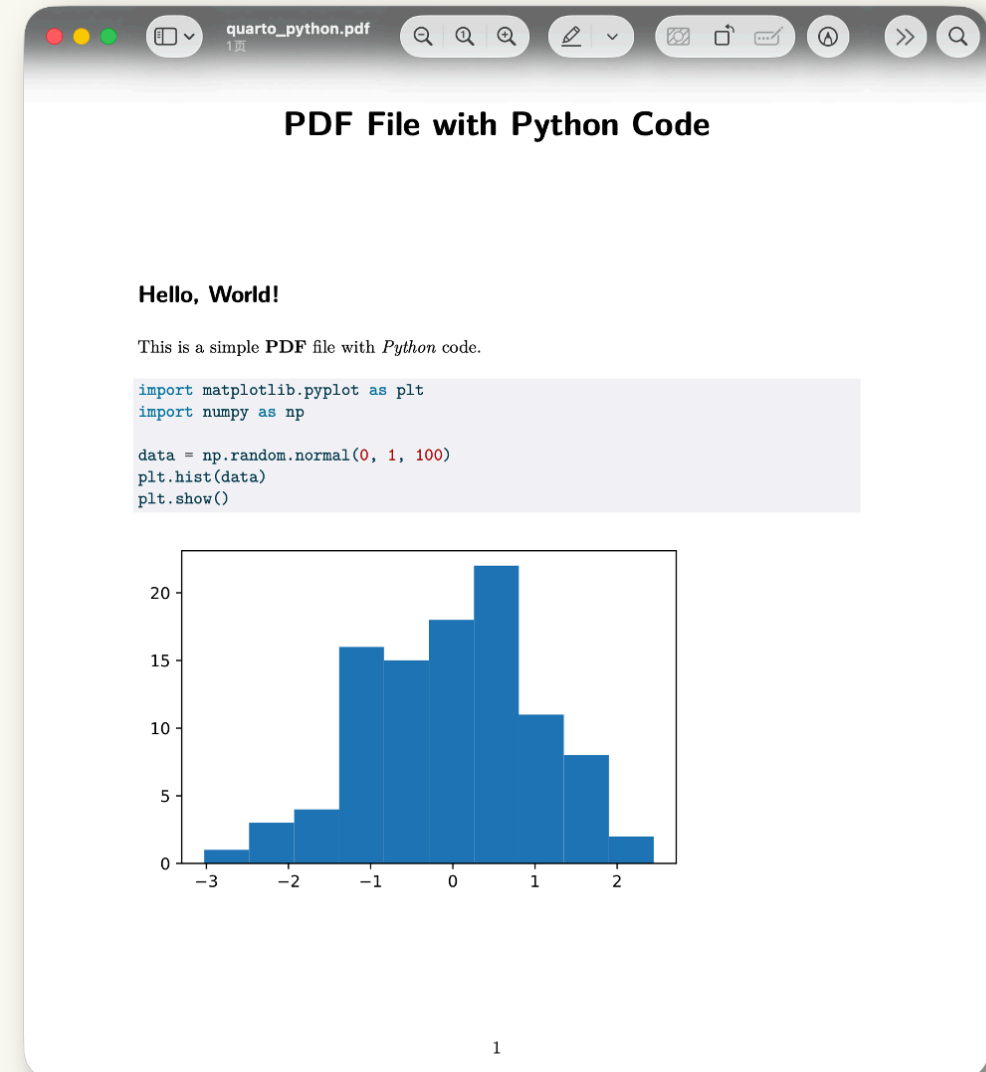


Original qmd file

Markdown + Python code chunks

```
1 ---
2 format: pdf
3 title: "PDF File with Python Code"
4 ---
5
6 # Hello, World!
7
8 This is a simple **PDF** file with *Python* code.
9
10 ```{python}
11 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
12 import numpy as np
13
14 data = np.random.normal(0, 1, 100)
15 plt.hist(data)
16 plt.show()
17 ```
```

Rendered PDF

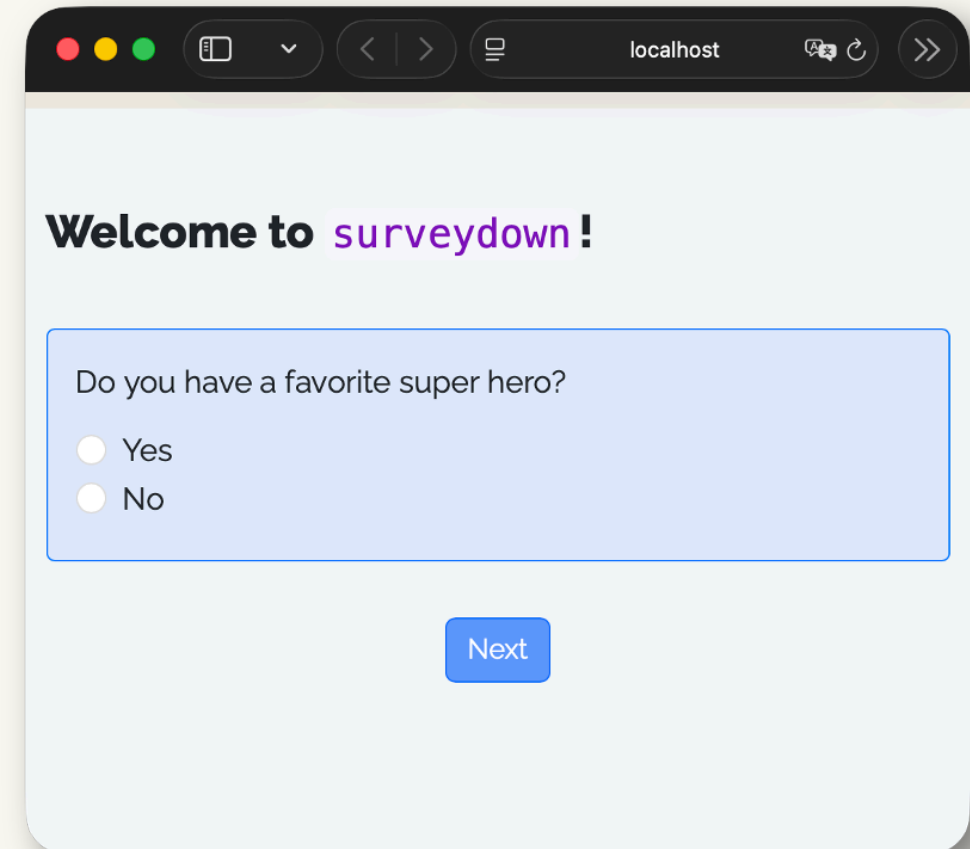




survey.qmd

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

Rendered Survey



localhost

Welcome to **surveydown**!

Do you have a favorite super hero?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Next

survey.qmd

YAML header for a “clean” output

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

survey.qmd

Load the `surveydown` Package

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

survey.qmd

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

Use triple-dash marker (---) to define survey pages

Quarto fences (:::) also OK:

```
::: {#welcome .sd-page}
```

Page content

```
:::
```

survey.qmd

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

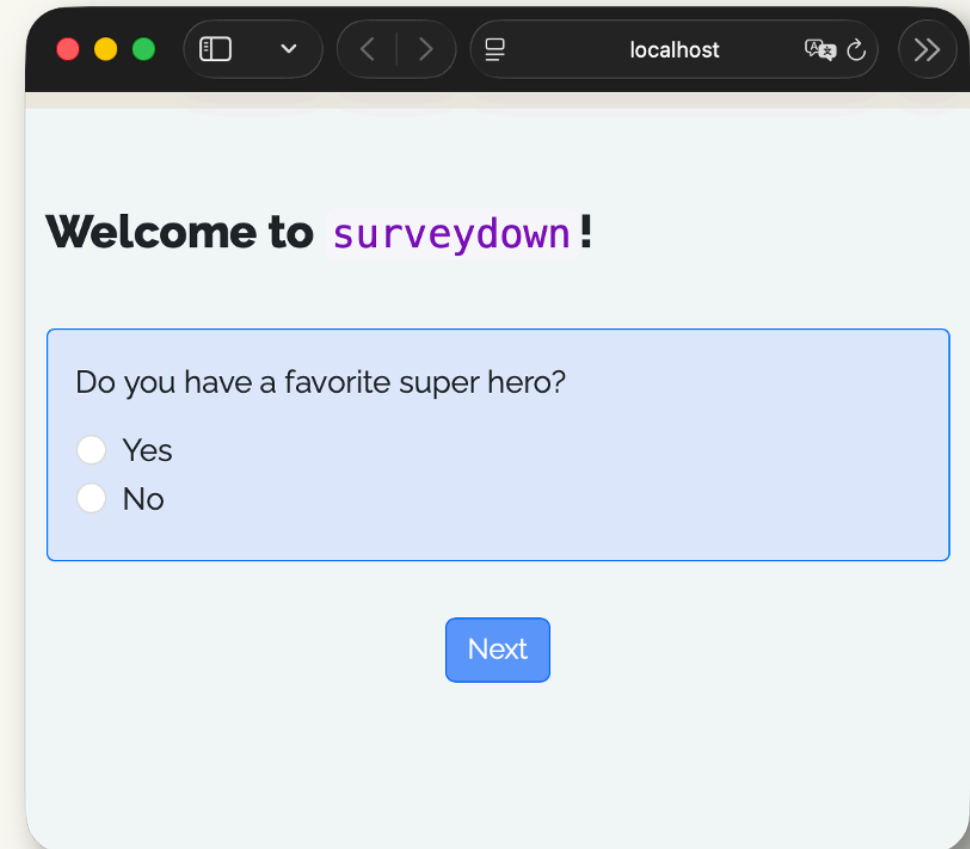
Page content

- Markdown for text, images, etc.
- `sd_question()` for survey questions
- `sd_next()` for page navigation

survey.qmd

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

Rendered Survey



localhost

Welcome to **surveydown**!

Do you have a favorite super hero?

☐ Yes

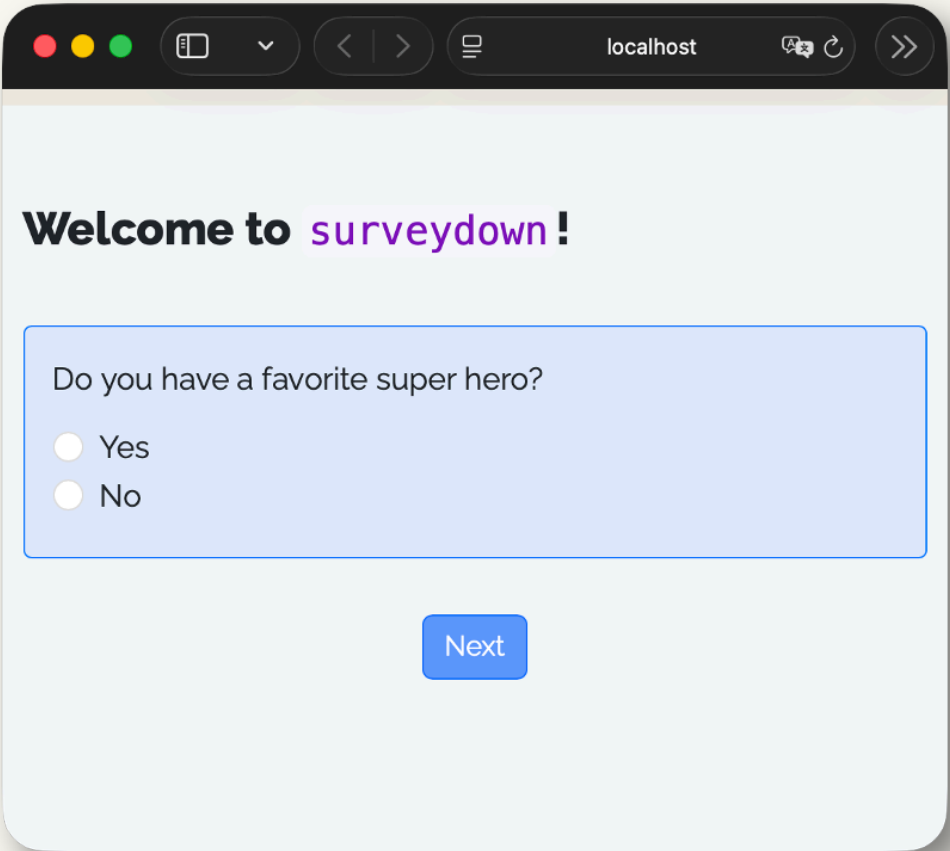
☐ No

Next

survey.qmd

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 ---
6
7 ```{r}
8 library(surveydown)
9 ```
10
11 --- welcome
12
13 # Welcome to `surveydown`!
14
15 ```{r}
16 sd_question(
17   type = "mc",
18   id    = "has_fav_hero",
19   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
20   option = c(
21     "Yes" = "yes",
22     "No"  = "no"
23   )
24 )
25
26 sd_next()
27 ```
28
29 --- some_other_page
30
31 Other content...
```

Rendered Survey



has_fav_hero
yes
no
no
yes

Wait a minute...

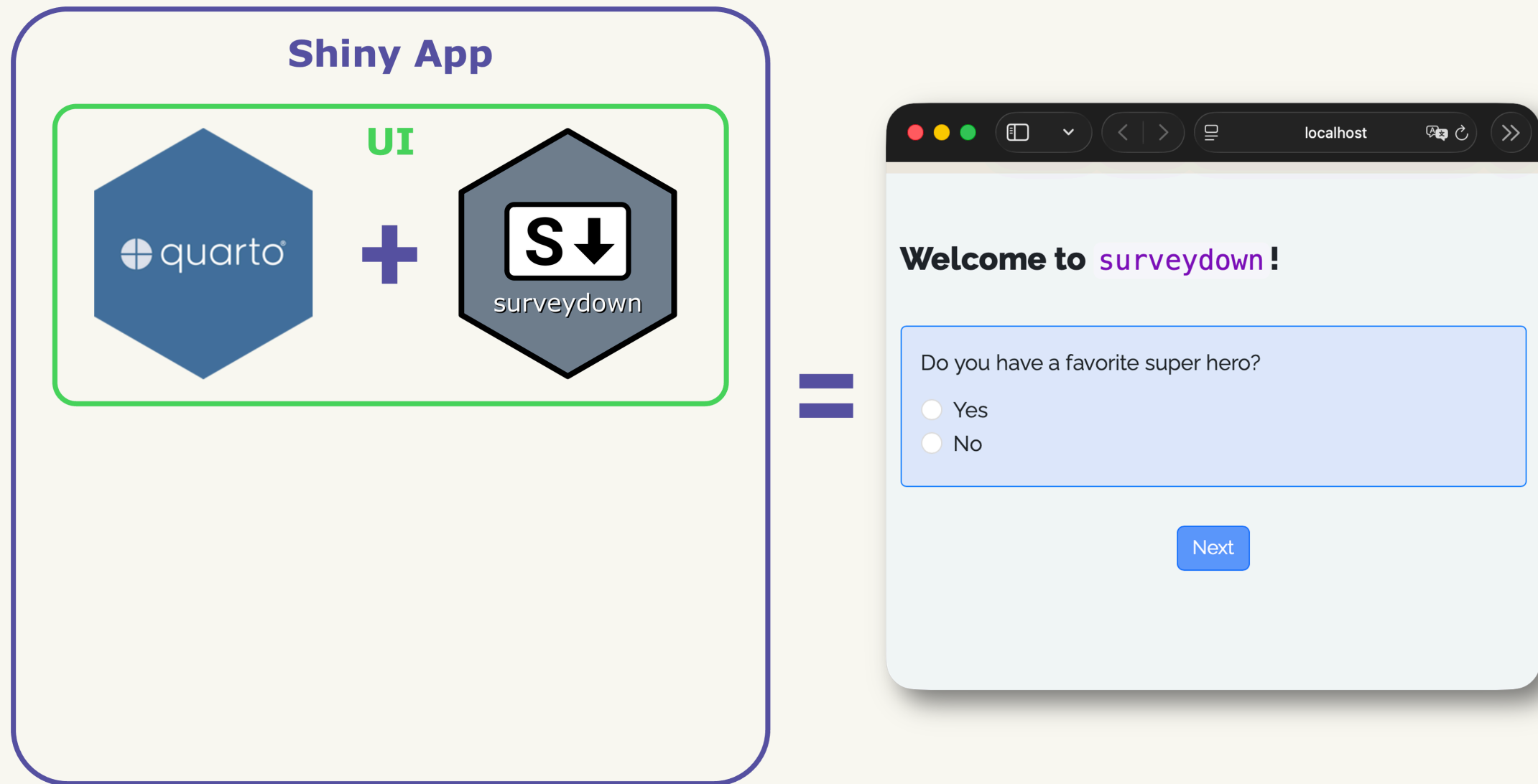
Quarto renders to **static** html pages, right?

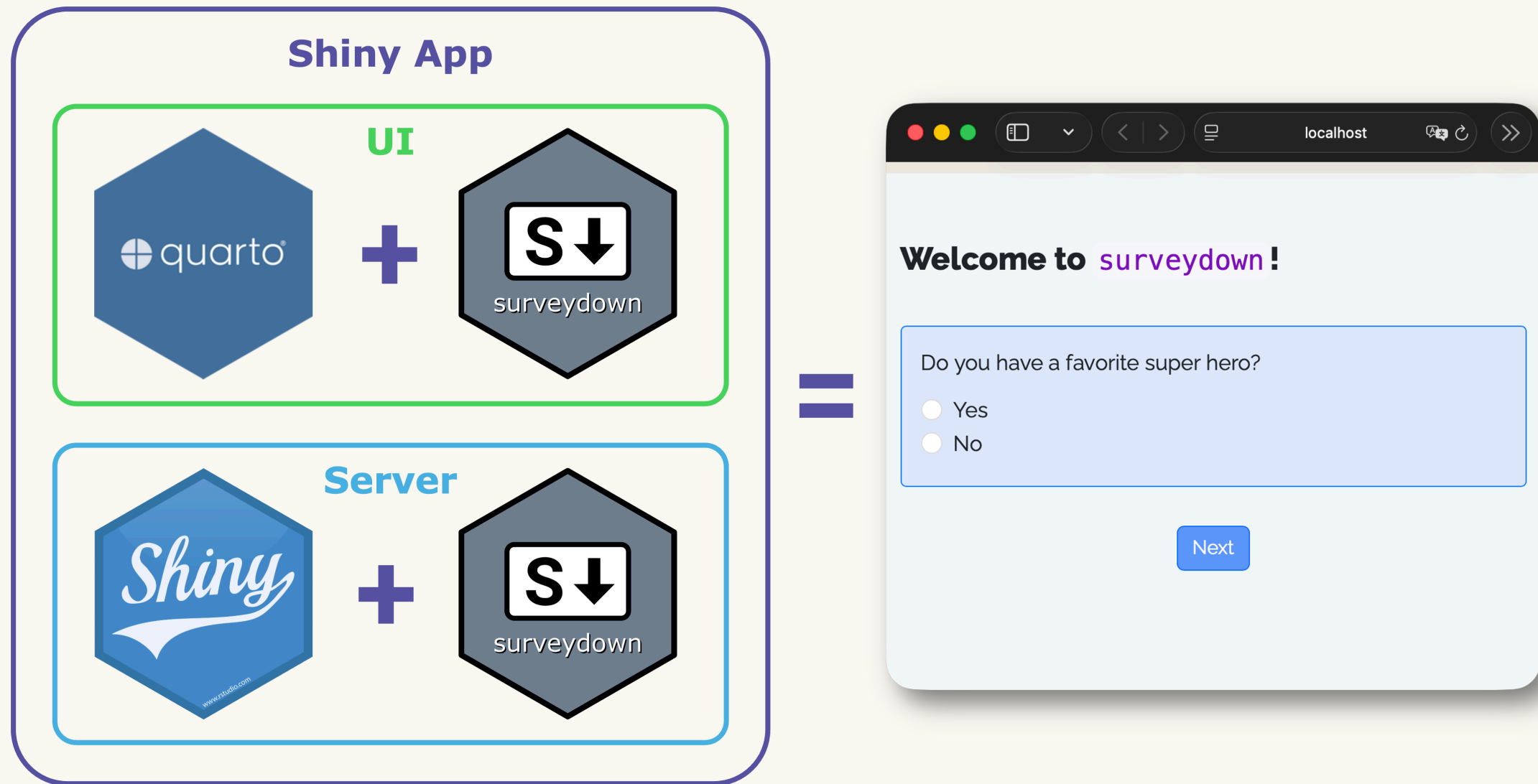


Shiny to the rescue!









A complete surveydown survey

`survey.qmd`

A **Quarto doc** defining the survey content (pages, text, images, questions, etc.).

`app.R`

An **R script** defining the survey Shiny app.

Don't panic!



app.R

```
1 library(surveydown)
2
3 ui ← sd_ui()
4
5 server ← function(input, output, session) {
6   sd_server()
7 }
8
9 }
10
11 shiny::shinyApp(ui = ui, server = server)
```

app.R

Run the `surveydown` server

```
1 library(surveydown)
2
3 ui ← sd_ui()
4
5 server ← function(input, output, session) {
6   sd_server()
7 }
8
9 }
10
11 shiny::shinyApp(ui = ui, server = server)
```

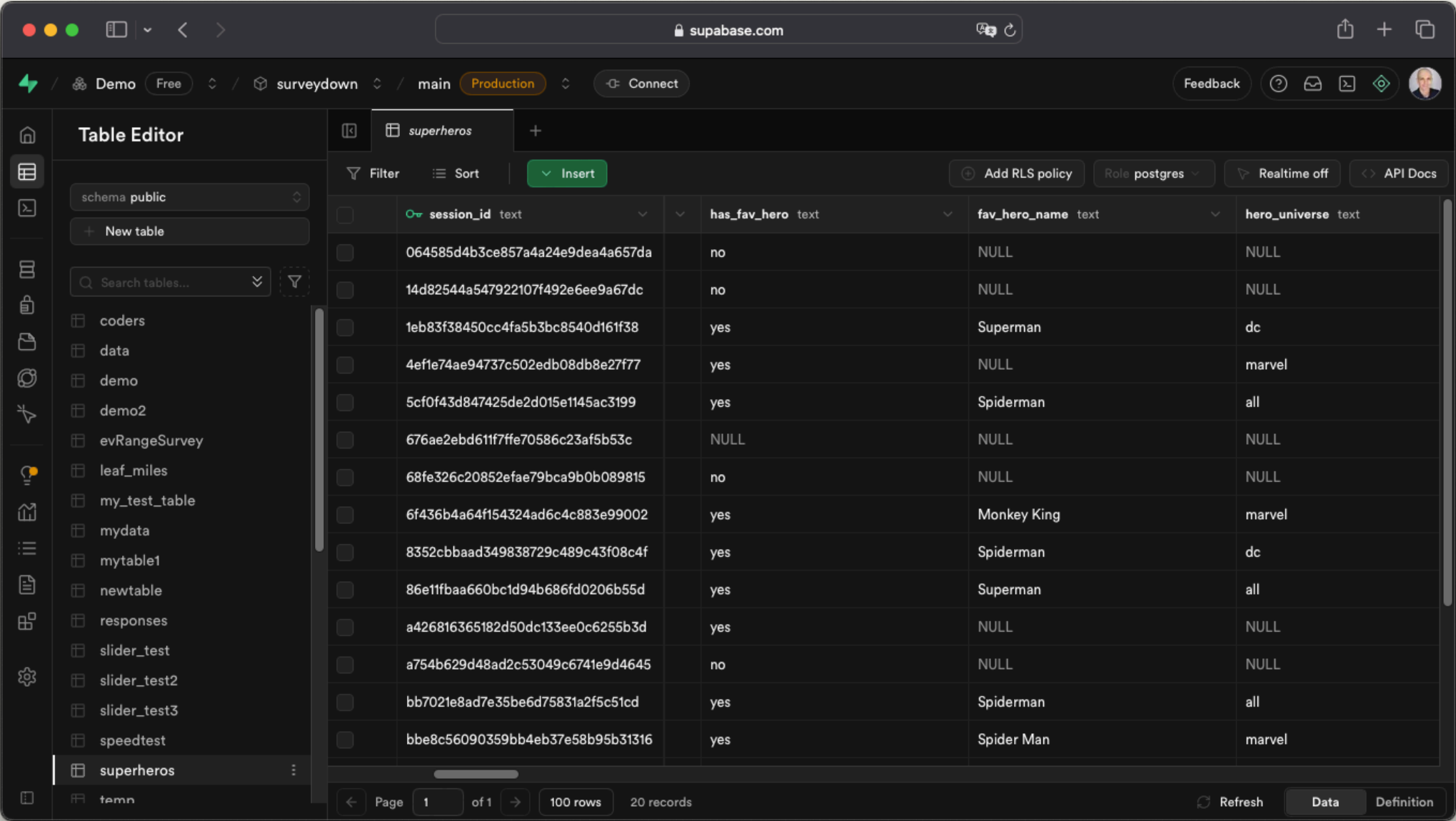
Wait a minute...

How do you store the response **data**?



PostgreSQL to the rescue!





app.R

Pass connection to `sd_server()`
Connect to the database

```
1 library(surveydown)
2
3 # sd_db_config()
4 db <- sd_db_connect()
5
6 ui <- sd_ui()
7
8 server <- function(input, output, session) {
9
10   sd_server(db)
11
12 }
13
14 shiny::shinyApp(ui = ui, server = server)
```

The screenshot shows an RStudio window titled "demo - main - RStudio". The interface includes a menu bar, a toolbar, and several panes. The left pane shows a script with the following R code:

```
1 library(surveydown)
2 library(dplyr)
3
4 db <- sd_db_connect()
5
6 data <- sd_get_data(db = db)
7
8 glimpse(data)
9
```

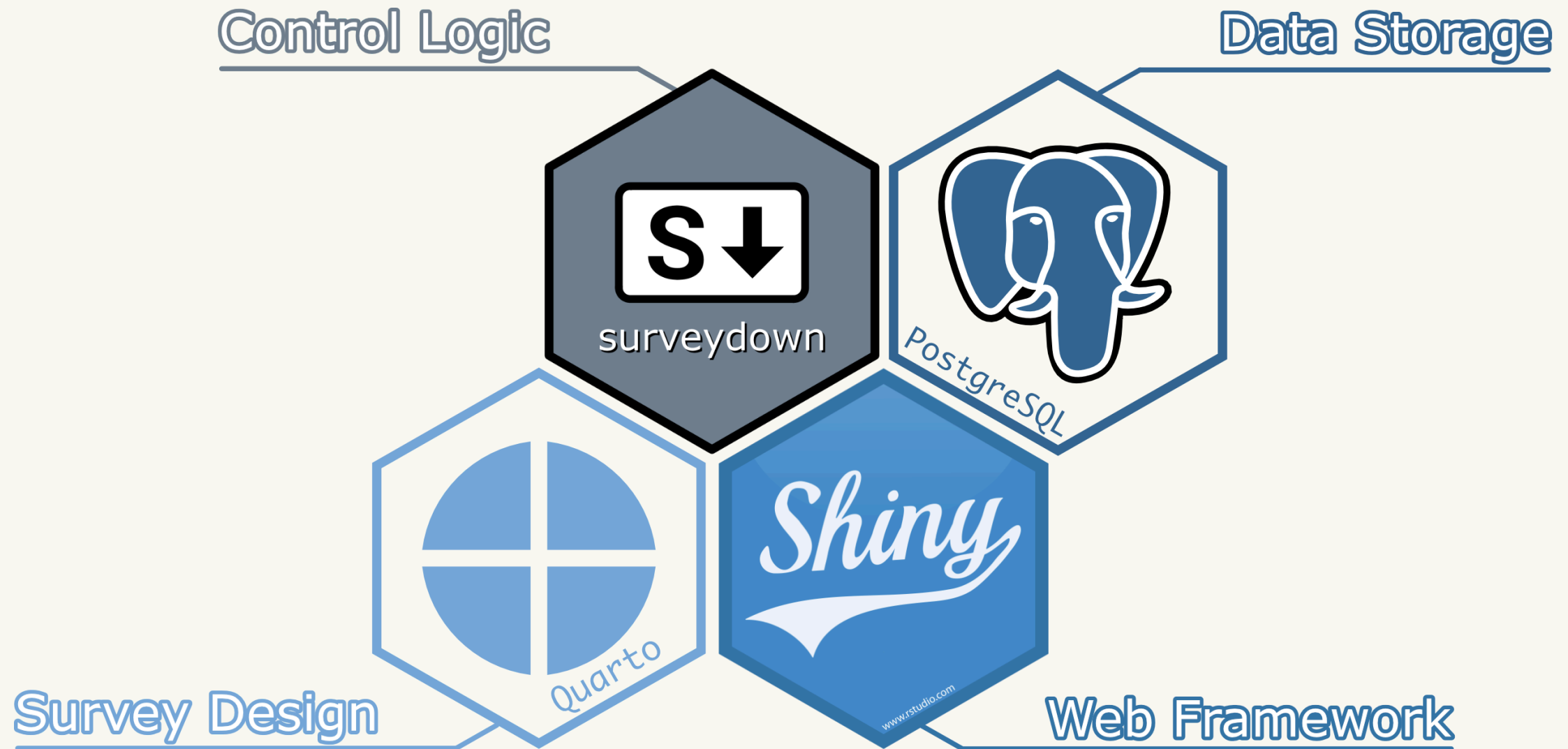
The right pane shows the console output for the executed code:

```
> db <- sd_db_connect()
✓ Successfully connected to the database.
>
> data <- sd_get_data(db = db)
>
> glimpse(data)
Rows: 20
Columns: 50
$ session_id           <chr> "5cf0f43d847425...
$ time_start           <chr> "2025-08-15 15:...
$ time_end             <chr> "2025-08-15 15:...
$ completion_code      <chr> "37081685", "60...
$ browser              <chr> "Safari v26, i0...
$ ip_address           <chr> "140.248.0.0", ...
$ has_fav_hero         <chr> "yes", "yes", "...
$ fav_hero_name        <chr> "Spiderman", "S...
$ hero_universe        <chr> "all", "dc", "a...
$ hero_qualities       <chr> "strength, flyi...
$ dream_power          <chr> "telepathy", "t...
$ responsibility_scale <chr> "10", "8.1", "1...
$ villain_encounter    <chr> "help_backup", ...
$ superhero_rating     <chr> NA, NA, NA, NA,...
$ superhero_rating_spiderman <chr> "love", "love",...
$ superhero_rating_batman <chr> "love", NA, "li...
$ superhero_rating_wonder_woman <chr> "love", NA, "li...
```

The bottom status bar shows "9:1 (Top Level) Copilot: Completion response received. R Script". The bottom pane includes tabs for "Files", "Plots", "Packages", "Help", "Viewer", and "Presentation".

What is **surveydown**?





What can **surveydown** do?

surveydown is feature-packed!

surveydown.org

AboutDocumentationTemplatesBlog

FAQ

Documentation

Features & Roadmap

Survey Basics

Getting Started

Basic Components

Question Development

Defining Questions

Question Types

Question Formatting

Custom Questions

Survey Design Concepts

Survey Settings

Page Navigation

Conditional Logic

System Translations

External Resources

Interactivity

Reactivity

Randomization

External Redirect

Data Management

Storing Data

Fetching Data

Features

Feature	Docs	Version	Discussion
Wide variety of question types	Question Types	v0.0.1	105 , 109
Conditionally show questions	Conditional Display	v0.0.1	
Markdown formatting for options and buttons	Markdown Formatting	v0.0.1	
Require specific questions or all questions be answered	Required Questions	v0.0.2	
Support for bootstrap themes	Themes	v0.0.4	
Customizable scss theme file	Themes	v0.0.4	
Ability to Ignore the database connection	Supabase Ignore	v0.0.8	
Time stamps recorded for each question and page interaction		v0.0.9	
Progress bar that updates on each question interaction	Progress Bar	v0.0.9	
Customizable progress bar color and position on page	Progress Bar	v0.0.9	
Ability to use latest survey results in the survey itself	Fetching Data	v0.1.1	
Pass parameters through the url	Reactive	v0.2.2	92

On this page

[surveydown package](#)

[Features](#)

[To Do](#)

[sdstudio package](#)

[Features](#)

[To Do](#)

Site made with

and

quarto

Feature Highlights

Question types

Conditional logic

12 Built-in Question Types

text

textarea

numeric

mc

mc_multiple

mc_buttons

mc_multiple_buttons

select

slider

slider_numeric

date

daterange

Question Type: text

```
1 sd_question(  
2   type = "text",  
3   id   = "fav_hero_name",  
4   label = "Who is your favorite super hero?"  
5 )
```



Who is your favorite super hero?

Question Type: mc_buttons

```
1 sd_question(  
2   type = "mc_buttons",  
3   id   = "dream_power",  
4   label = "If you could have ONE superpower, which would  
5   option = c(  
6     "🕸 Web-slinging" = "webslinging",  
7     "🛡 Super Strength" = "strength",  
8     "✈ Flight" = "flight",  
9     "🧠 Telepathy" = "telepathy",  
10    "⚡ Super Speed" = "speed"  
11  ),  
12  direction = "vertical"  
13 )
```



If you could have ONE superpower?

 Web-slinging Swing through cities
 Super Strength Lift anything
 Flight Soar through the skies
 Telepathy Read minds
 Super Speed Faster than lightning

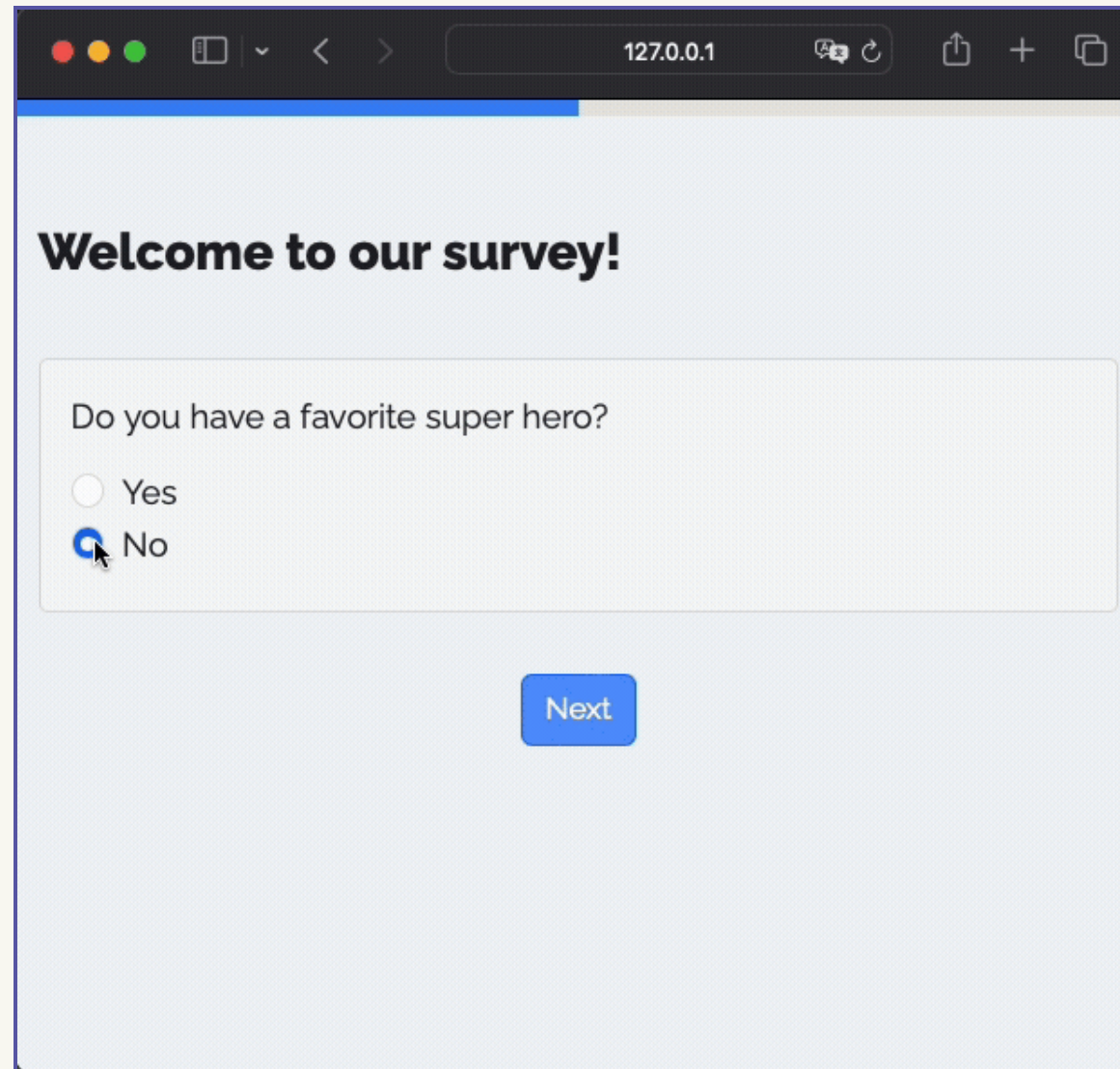
Conditional logic

Conditional showing

Conditional skipping

Conditional stopping

Conditional showing - `sd_show_if()`



A screenshot of a web browser window displaying a survey. The browser's address bar shows the URL `127.0.0.1`. The survey content is as follows:

Welcome to our survey!

Do you have a favorite super hero?

☐ Yes

☒ No

Next

Conditional showing - `sd_show_if()`

survey.qmd

```
1 # Conditional Question
2 sd_question(
3   type = "mc",
4   id    = "has_fav_hero",
5   label = "Do you have a favorite hero?",
6   option = c("Yes" = "yes", "No" = "no")
7 )
8
9 # Target Question
10 sd_question(
11   type = "text",
12   id    = "fav_hero",
13   label = "Who is your favorite super hero?"
14 )
```

app.R

```
1 # Inside server
2 sd_show_if(
3   input$has_fav_hero == "yes" ~ "fav_hero"
4 )
```

Condition ~ Target

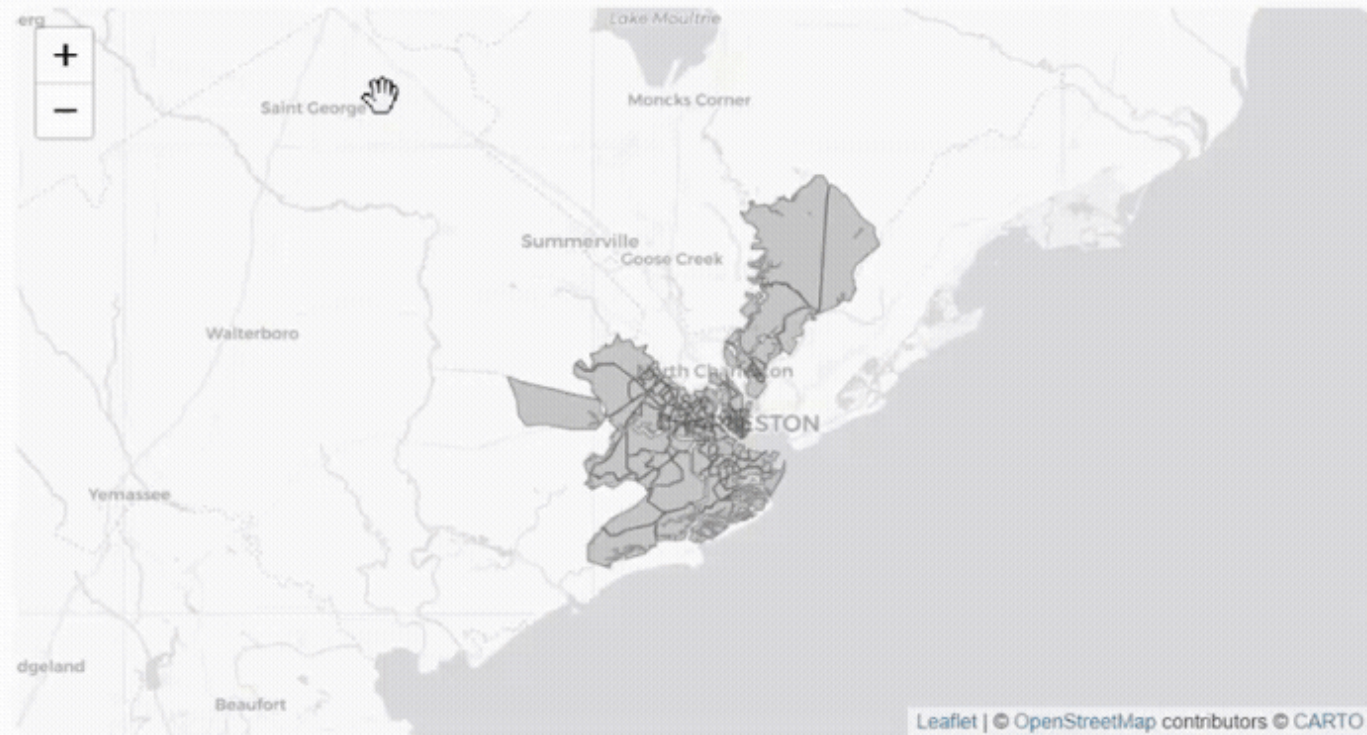
“If {condition}, then show {target}”

If it works in **Shiny**,
it works in **surveydown**.

Embedding an interactive map with **leaflet**:

Question 1: Social Vulnerability is how likely people are to face greater harm or impact on their lives after disruptive hazard events like flooding based on social or economic conditions like income or transportation access.

Please review the map of the City of Charleston, South Carolina, and select the areas you believe are more socially vulnerable to the impacts of hazardous events.

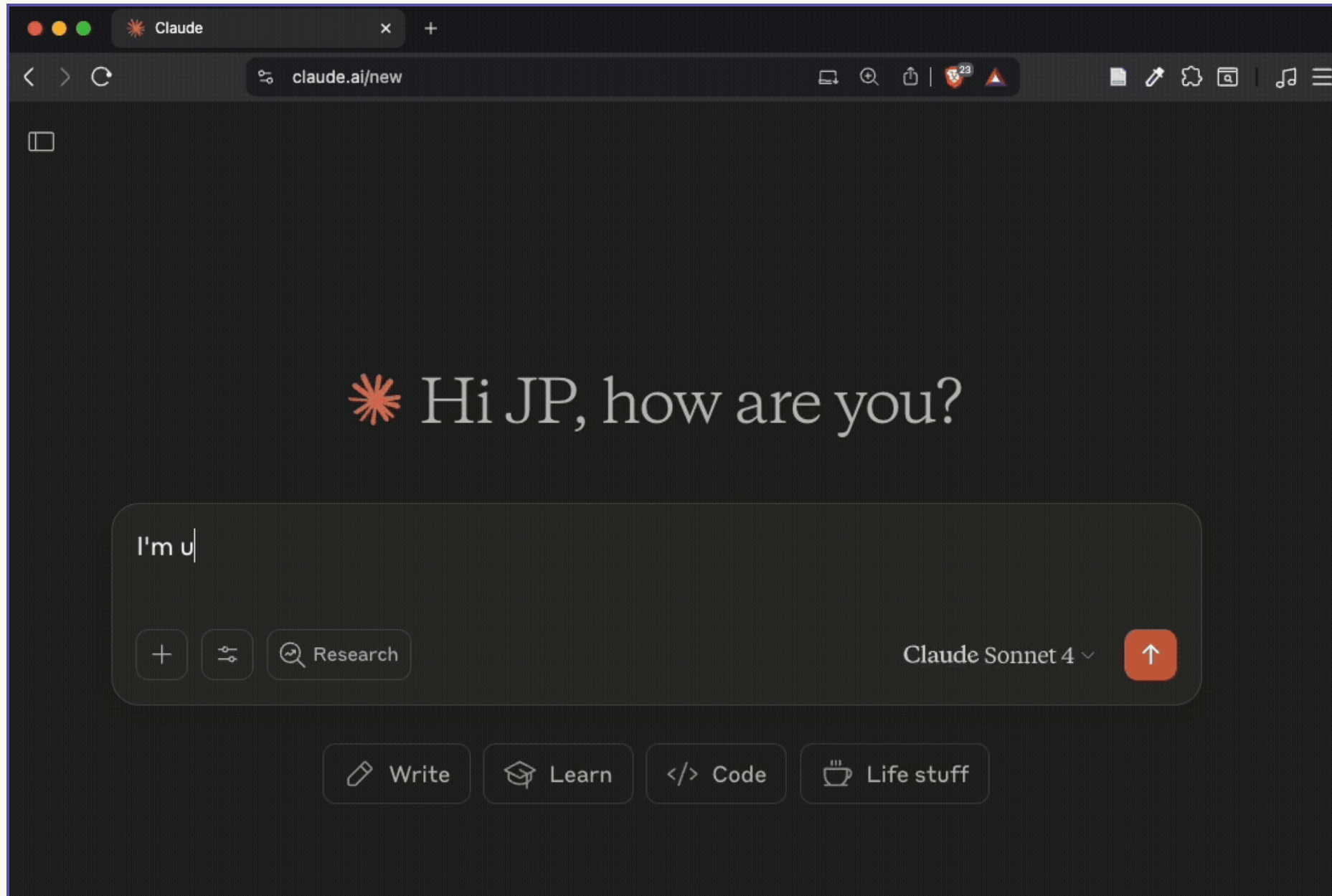


Next Question



surveydown + LLMs
is pretty cool

Generate surveys with LLMs!



What's next?

Try out the companion `sdstudio` package:

```
sdstudio::launch()
```


surveydown Studio

Build

Preview

Responses

Structure

Page: welcome

+T

+Q

T

🧑 Welcome to the...

Q

has_fav_hero | mc

Do you have a favorite super hero?

Q

fav_hero_name | text

Who is your favorite super hero?

Page: hero_details

+T

+Q

T

Tell us about your...

Q

hero_universe | mc

Which superhero universe do you prefer?

Q

hero_qualities | mc_multiple

What qualities do you find most appealing in superheroes? (Select all that apply)

Page: powers

+T

+Q

T

If you could have...

Code

survey.qmd

app.R

```
1 ---
2 format: html
3 echo: false
4 warning: false
5 theme: [superhero, custom.scss]
6 barcolor: "#e74c3c"
7 ---
8
9 ```{r}
10 library(surveydown)
11 ```
12
13 ::: {.sd_page id=welcome}
14
15 # 🧑 Welcome to the Ultimate Superhero Survey! 🧑 ♀
16
17 Thank you for participating in our research on superhero preferences and
18 powers! This survey will help us understand what makes superheroes
19 appealing to different people.
20
21 **This survey should take about 3-5 minutes to complete.**
22
23 <br>
24 ```{r}
25 sd_question(
26   type = "mc",
27   id = "has_fav_hero",
28   label = "Do you have a favorite super hero?",
29   option = c("Yes" = "yes", "No" = "no")
30 )
```

127.0.0.1

surveydown StudioBuildPreviewResponses

 **Welcome to the Ultimate Superhero Survey!** 

Thank you for participating in our research on superhero preferences and powers! This survey will help us understand what makes superheroes appealing to different people.

This survey should take about 3-5 minutes to complete.

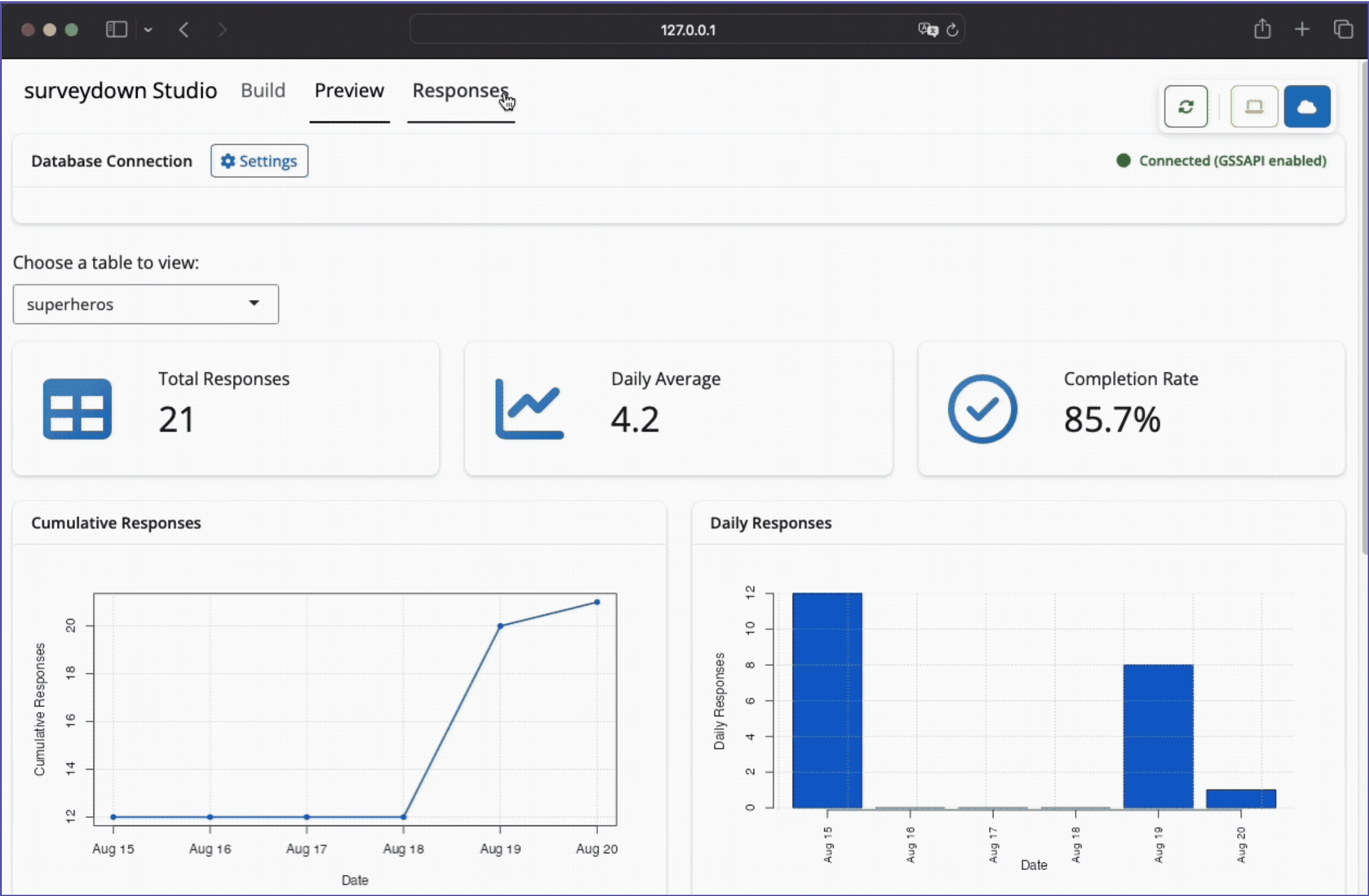
Do you have a favorite super hero? *

☒ Yes

☐ No

Who is your favorite super hero?

Next



With great power comes great responsibility.

Ways to help:

github.com/surveydown-dev/surveydown/

- Try it out!
- Give it a ★
- Post an issue
- Join the GitHub discussion
- Contribute a template



Meet the team!



John Helveston, Ph.D.



Pingfan Hu



Bogdan Bunea

surveydown.org



One more thing...

Workshop by Dr. John Helveston Tomorrow

jhelvy.github.io/2025-qux-surveydown-workshop/

Thursday Nov 6, **2:00 PM** UTC – 5, Eastern Time (U.S.)